



THE FIGHT FOR AMERICA'S FAMILIES

Exposing the Corruption in Family Courts and CPS.

They took my kids. They tried to silence me. They WON'T.

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 28

NORTH CAROLINA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside North Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

73

NORTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 70 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
26 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 25, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
31 OF 100

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NORTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 73 North Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 70 73 of 73 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$10,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 26 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 52.1% 26.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 73	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.0	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 73 of 73	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 31

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so North Carolina families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF NORTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	40	\$10,000	\$52,384	\$2,095,350
Lost Wages	32	\$6,000	\$73,394	\$2,348,600
Other Court Fees	18	\$0	\$3,056	\$55,000
Therapy / Evaluations	31	\$1,000	\$4,084	\$126,600
Reunification Services	21	\$275	\$2,346	\$49,275
GAL Fees	19	\$0	\$432	\$8,200
Asset Loss ¹	31	\$22,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$39,275	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$22,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		26	2.2 yrs
Mean months lost		35	2.9 yrs
Total across all families		1,658	138.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · NORTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in North Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		30	41%
Not provided		28	38%
Case closed: within last 2 years		9	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		5	7%
Active case: progress being made		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		33	45%
Unknown		19	26%
Family Court Only		15	21%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		6	8%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		15	21%
5 – 10 years		10	14%
5+ years		10	14%
3 – 5 years		9	12%
Over 10 years		8	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		23	32%
Visitation Only		13	18%
50/50 Joint		12	16%
Children in Foster Care		11	15%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		7	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Mecklenburg		5	7%
Burke		4	5%
Buncombe		3	4%
Union		3	4%
Rockingham		2	3%
Forsyth		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		18	25%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		12	16%
Other: (Short answer)		9	12%
Family Court		7	10%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		6	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — NORTH CAROLINA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



DSS with the help of my immigrant ex-wife not able to speak english the case worker fabricated false statements to build a case against me destroying our family. A corrupt evil DSS supervisor in charge said to me you did something wrong. DSS/JUDGE/GAL threaten brainwashed [...]

— FEDERICO

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Abused my child, incarcerated me twice, made me pay opposing counsel fees, denied me a court appointed attorney for Contempt, took my child away, retaliated.

— NORTH CAROLINA PARENT · JACQUELYN

MORE VOICES FROM NORTH CAROLINA

It has destroyed my kids. Plan and simple while leaving me broke from just trying to be a dad.

— JP

Ripped my world away broke my heart because I'm seeing now my children are suffering and being neglected from their own father.

— AMANDA

Ruined our lives. Traumatized my kids still to this day. Obliterated my purpose. Never one time helped us as a family they only ripped us apart. Everything was based on lies.

— BRITTANY

My kids have already lost one parent. Now cps is helping them lose another. This is inhumane

— LEAH

They destroyed the life my children and I had. I now have no life with my children.

— STEPHANIE

The court has destroyed my family and my children childhood and mental well being.

— CATHY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Ripped us into shreds, torn us.. broken us.. hurt us so badly. Traumatized my children to where they NEEDED therapy & things they NEVER needed PRIOR. Yet they use that as reason to KEEP THEM. Altered my records & my husband's, demanding things from our jobs which caused us to be [...]

— BRITTANY

Taken my children's mother away with judges that won't make decisions and forensic interviews that are never read. I feel like nobody cares but me.

— VALERIE

This system has destroyed the soul of a child, her father's grief cannot be put into words, our children have missed out on months, if not years of having their own parents mentally healthy due to the stress and trauma, they have endured trauma of their own due to living with a [...]

— ERIN

Compete and utter destruction and trauma along with PTSD. Allowing a Narcissist to almost destroy my kids by trying to emotionally, financially and physically ruin me.

— JENNIFER

The system has caused irreversible trauma and stress. There have been delays on plans for our family and home renovations.

— STEVEN

They have destroyed our family! Gave my boys to a monster who is in jail awaiting trial for unaliving my oldest son n now my 2 other boys are back in state custody with no contact. I was always supposed to be kept in thier lives . This was a reunification case not adoption !

— FELICIA

has gave him temp custody he has no car no job etc and i moved back judge won't grant a ex parte even thou he could be in another state kids haven't talked me in 3 n half weeks . i been back since dec 12 still haven't seen them. oh and the 6yr old supposed have started school.

— TAYLOR

The system has destroyed our way of life and made life a struggle for us because we are forced to spend time with and have to co-parent with our abuser. He continues to emotionally and verbally abuse our daughters and attempts to do the same to me. Luckily years of counseling [...]

— LAURA

CPS took advantage of my depression and used it as a tool for attempted murder! Completely annihilated my family.

— NICOLE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



No due process from a cheating spouse, quick Absolute-Divorce within months (lied about timeframe). Created hostile environment after divorce and used false allegations and “mean words” to secure DVPO; limiting access to son. Alienation has been used to make some hate his father [...]

— SHAUN

Ripped it apart. Took a part of me away and ill never be the same until i get them back

— ERICA

Avery county department of social services have destroyed my entire life for their financial gain. They never had our families best interest and defnately not my children's

— CARRIE

This system has separated my children from their mother, stolen milestones we can never get back, and forced my family to live in uncertainty while I fight to be heard. It has not just cost us time and money, it has cost my babies the safety, love, and daily bond they were [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son was always so happy, he had a glow about him from birth and was always smiling, such a healthy, happy, big baby boy. And when CPS ripped him out of my arms, the traumatic cry he let out is something I'll never forget. They admitted all he did was cry for 2 weeks straight [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son rarely sees some of his siblings. It has absolutely taken away a lot of should be memories.

— CHRISTINE

They tore my children out of a loving safe home.... This distorted my whole life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Hell right here on earth every second of every day non stop torture

— JENNIFER

The system openly ignored the fact that my children were being exposed to Marijuana - being used in front of children in an illegal state, unhealthy living conditions, unsafe sleeping arrangements and had a lack of proper hygiene and grooming, to keep the children in a town [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Turns out "family court "forgot the family part . Best interest of the child" sounds good, but in practice, it can feel like budgets and procedure matter more than children's actual needs. We lived the gap between the slogan and the reality. Children deserve more than a slogan .

— BECKA

Caused depression and PTSD, living in constant flight or fight

— TAMEKA

Taken my child through an emergency order riddled with false allegations and indicated she was adaptable for placement families....held her in cps custody over 1 year with still no hearing to date

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is not a system to protect children, it is a system of lies and manipulation to obtain funds which ever way they can extort it!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system put my child in the custody of an abusive grandparent who isolates her from me and other loving people

— MANDY

I was wrongful accused and DSS has no proof of allegations. My oldest daughter came home. But the youngest is still being alienated from me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Severe prolonged psychological damage and traumatic mental health physical deterioration. PTSD, depression near death. Tremendous strain and stress near loss of external family. Word's can't describe. Death. Death of hope. Stroke, heart attack, seizures job loss reputation [...]

— TRAVIS

Destroyed my family and I have been living in my car for 6 1/2 years and I have a apartment now but then I was always beating myself up and trying to wrap my mind around what in the heck happened and what did I do wrong that I was convinced I must've and I thought they targeted [...]

— AIMEE

Alienated me from constitutional fatherhood and the quiet enjoyment thereof

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Since my child has been in public schools I, have had multiple cases opened. I have even had multiple cases opened in the same week.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely tore apart

— HEATHER

Tried to rip us apart as in they tried to make my husband and I divorce told us that they had someone that wanted to adopt our children. We presume it was my in-laws because they've been trying to get me to sign my son over to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Multiple counties conspired together to destroy my home and peace of mind.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined our entire life!!!

— BRITNY

The family court system has broken my faith in the American Justice system, hurt my mental health, my family's savings is gone letting mine and my child's abuser win absolutely everything. A man that hasn't seen or talked to his child in 2 years and hurt him has full and complete [...]

— REBECCA

I have developed an autoimmune disorder. I have lost a ton of friends and hair. I have high blood pressure and trouble sleeping. I have started blood pressure medication and sleeping medicine. I'm only 31.

— TORI

It has affected my mental and emotional state. I feel like I am losing hope and not being treated like a human being. My Son is my reason for everything and now that he is gone I feel like I have nothing left in this world.

— CHELSEA

My son who is taking college courses in highschool is a good kid but has to endure his father's rage episodes where he has been strangled, pushed and father held my son down on the ground with his foot, banged his head on the desk, and threatened since 11 he would go to a foster [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

45 North Carolina parents submitted ranked quotes. 44 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/nc.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this North Carolina report comes from North Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in North Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 73 North Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of North Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.